

For this slice of the Indian population, whom I like to call the urban professional mass affluent, dealing with this transition is breaking new territory where there are no old rules of tradition and precedence to fall back upon. Around thirty to forty years ago the norm was (and continues to be in smaller towns and rural India) that ageing parents were looked after by their eldest son, and because the families mostly lived together, the transition from one generation to the other was gradual. Slowly the younger family member would take over the various tasks of running the house and finances – so things like location of documents, names on bank accounts and location of locker keys weren't such an issue. Usually the sisters' dowries took care of their inheritance issues (most signed over their rights to the brothers) and the brothers would sort out the family assets the best they could.

But for the urban professional mass affluent Indian born post Independence, the story is very different. The parents mostly continue to lead independent lives, with assistance now and then, and very little intervention in the day-to-day running of the house or finances.

However, smoothening the end-of-life issues needs more attention than ever before. In the generations gone by, the focus was on care and who would provide it, but for the current set of urban oldies, the concerns are more about lifestyle, independence and space. Issues to be sorted out are end-of-life choices, the continuation of the accustomed life for the spouse left behind, paperwork, bequeathing real assets and closure of debts.

But my dipstick survey among people like us tells me that this conversation jostles with the 'birds and the bees' talk with the kids in terms of the squeamishness.

What makes the conversation on end-of-life choices tough to initiate is also the fear of appearing overeager to discuss your own inheritance. Professors Marsha A. Goetting and Vicki L. Schmall in Montana State University Guide write:

Sometimes people hesitate to discuss financial concerns with their parents for fear of appearing overly interested in their inheritances. After all, talking about passing on Mom and Dad's money usually